TWIN STRIKE

WE GET A LEG OVER APRILIA'S MADE-IN-INDIA RS 457 AT THE GRUELLING KARI MOTOR SPEEDWAY

BY DIPAYAN DUTTA

Engine
457 cc, liquid-cooled, twin-cyl

Power
47.6 bhp @ 9,400 rpm

Price ₹4.10 lakh (ex-showroom)

Design is subjective, but do you even love motorcycles if you don't think Aprilias are unconditionally beautiful? The same goes for the 457; the design is very unapologetically derived from the RSV4 right down to those cool MotoGP-inspired winglets on the front; the 457 looks like a scaled-down version of its bigger sibling. One of the elements that you have to love is the way the fairing neatly integrates the belly exhaust. There's a 5-inch TFT colour display for the instruments that gets Bluetooth connectivity as well. I wish adjustable levers were a part of the standard kit.

The Aprilia RS 457 is based on a dual-beam aluminium frame that adds the rigidity it needs for proper direction changes. Front and rear springs are adjustable for preload with a 41 mm USD upfront with 120 mm of travel and a mono-shock at the rear. Braking comes from a pair of discs with a 320 mm floating disc up front and a 220mm disc at the rear. The brakes and the callipers are Bybre and use organic pads instead of top-shelf Brembo signature callipers and sintered pads. The rearset footpegs and the front slant forward over the sizeable tank, but that also means taller riders fit on the bike without feeling cramped. Off the track, you just slide forward on the seat and there's a pretty comfortable upright position there.

Thumb the starter and bring the 457 cc twin to life, and you're greeted by a surprisingly mellow hum. But wring that ride-by-wire throttle open and you'll get a taste of what this motor is capable of. But first a look at the numbers—the 457 cc inline twin makes 47 bhp at a sky-high 9,700 rpm, but 43.5Nm of torque comes in as low as 6,750 rpm. It is exactly where you want the power to be considering it tips the wet scales at 175 kg. Ride modes include Rain, Road and Sport, with three levels of ABS and traction intervention. Overall, the engine is pretty tractable and should be easy to ride in the city. Out on the track, the motor is an absolute beast hitting 170+ kmph easily on both of Kari's short straights.

The only thing that wasn't up to the mark was the brakes. I also found myself wishing for more feeling in the levers. The majority of this could be offset by upgrading to sintered pads but one couldn't help but feel like full-price Brembos would have pushed up the value offering of the motorcycle exponentially. ■

